

# STING is KING

In the season of sting operations, all it takes is a CD for every political party to claim its own version of the truth. However, the grainy images and double roles by several players show that while much has been uncovered the truth is still elusive.



## ON THE HOUSE

DATE: 22-07-08

Parliamentary traditions hit a new low as three BJP MPs flash wads of currency allegedly offered to them as bribe.

**RESULT:** Government wins vote but loses trust.



## SADHVI STROKES

DATE: 01-08-08

BJP renegade Uma Bharati alleged that the Trustgate was stage-managed by the BJP to tarnish its opponents.

**RESULT:** Sting backfires as visuals go against claims.

■ By Shafi Rahman

National politics, it seems, is now divided between those who did a sting and those who didn't. It was spurred by a private television channel that cited several loose ends to refuse to air a sting on the cash-for-vote scam it co-produced with the BJP. During the week, like characters in search of an author, everyone who feted and featured in the original CD—Parliament members, sundry cronies, the accusers, the accused—spilled on to other sting CDs. Once upon a time, CDs featured songs set to popular tunes eulogising their own and running down opponents. Now the CDs mostly contain footage shot on hidden camera showing the opponent naked. The nation sat rivetted as the trailer to the mother sting was beamed live from

the Lok Sabha during the trust vote with three BJP MPs waving wads of currency allegedly received from the UPA for shifting sides. The television channel, they said, had it all on camera and would soon be airing it. It didn't and chickened out, and preferred to hand it over to the Speaker of the Lok Sabha. The sting CD is now being examined by a seven-member committee appointed by Somnath Chatterjee.

Days later, the sting sheet got meatier with Bharatiya Janshakti Party leader Uma Bharati grabbing the chance to emerge from political obscurity with a new sting CD "to prove that Trustgate was stage-managed by the BJP to tarnish its opponents and the trust vote". Last weekend saw BJP coming out with "irrefutable technological evidence" of Samajwadi Party (SP) General Secretary Amar Singh's attempt to bribe